Your first 30 days in the Netherlands

The checklist — Dutch Survival Hacks

Week 1 — Get registered

The first thing you do is register. Everything else depends on it.

- **Book a gemeente appointment** — do this before or as soon as you arrive
  - Find your city's website (e.g. amsterdam.nl, denhaag.nl, rotterdam.nl)
  - Look for "inschrijven" or "first registration"
  - Bring: valid passport, rental contract or proof of address
  - Note: if you're staying 4+ months, registration is mandatory within 5 days
- **Register at the gemeente**
  - You'll automatically receive your **BSN** (citizen service number) at this appointment
  - Without a BSN you can't open a bank account, get health insurance or start work
- **Give your BSN to your employer** — they need it before your first salary payment

Week 2 — DigiD + bank account

- **Apply for DigiD** at digid.nl
  - You need your BSN and a Dutch address
  - A letter arrives by post within 5–7 days — don't lose it
  - DigiD is your key to every Dutch government website
- **Open a Dutch bank account**
  - ABN AMRO, ING and Rabobank all work with new expats
  - Bring: passport, BSN, proof of address
  - Some banks require an appointment — book online in advance
  - Tip: Bunq and Revolut work without a BSN if you need something fast

Week 3 — Health insurance + daily life

- **Get health insurance (zorgverzekering)** — this is mandatory
  - You have 4 months from registration to arrange this
  - Basic package costs roughly €135–165/month
  - Compare insurers at zorgwijzer.nl or independer.nl
  - Biggest insurers: Zilveren Kruis, VGZ, Menzis, CZ, DSW
- **Check if you qualify for zorgtoeslag** (healthcare allowance) — income-based subsidy; apply at toeslagen.nl (you need DigiD in Week 4)
- **Register with a GP (huisarts)** — find one at huisartszoeker.nl; bring BSN and address
- **Get an OV-chipkaart** — order at ov-chipkaart.nl or use contactless bank card on most transport

Week 4 — Tax & benefits

- **Activate your DigiD** — use the code from the letter that arrived in Week 2
- **Ask HR about the 30% ruling** — do this now. Tax benefit for many expats; employer must apply within 4 months of start date.
- **Check toeslagen** at toeslagen.nl — zorgtoeslag, huurtoeslag; you need DigiD
- **Register at belastingdienst.nl** if you're self-employed or have income from abroad

Dutch terms you'll keep running into

Term	What it means
BSN	Burgerservicenummer — your citizen service number. You need it for everything.
DigiD	Your digital identity for all Dutch government websites.
Gemeente	Your local municipality office. Where you register.
Huisarts	GP. Register before you need one.
Zorgverzekering	Health insurance. Mandatory.
Zorgtoeslag	Healthcare allowance — subsidy on your premium.
OV-chipkaart	Public transport card.
Belastingdienst	Dutch tax authority. belastingdienst.nl has English.
30%-regeling	30% ruling — tax benefit for some expats.
Toeslagen	Government allowances (healthcare, rent, childcare).
Inschrijven	To register. You'll see this word everywhere.

Useful links

- digid.nl — apply for and activate your DigiD
- government.nl — official information in English
- belastingdienst.nl — tax authority
- zorgwijzer.nl — compare health insurance
- huisartszoeker.nl — find a GP
- ov-chipkaart.nl — public transport card
- toeslagen.nl — allowances
- dutchsurvivalhacks.seniorease.eu — more tips and guides